

Project Title: Modernizing Complex Administrative Workflows Through System-Level UX Redesign

Timeline: 6+ months

Role: Product Designer

Team: BA, Development, QA, Stakeholders

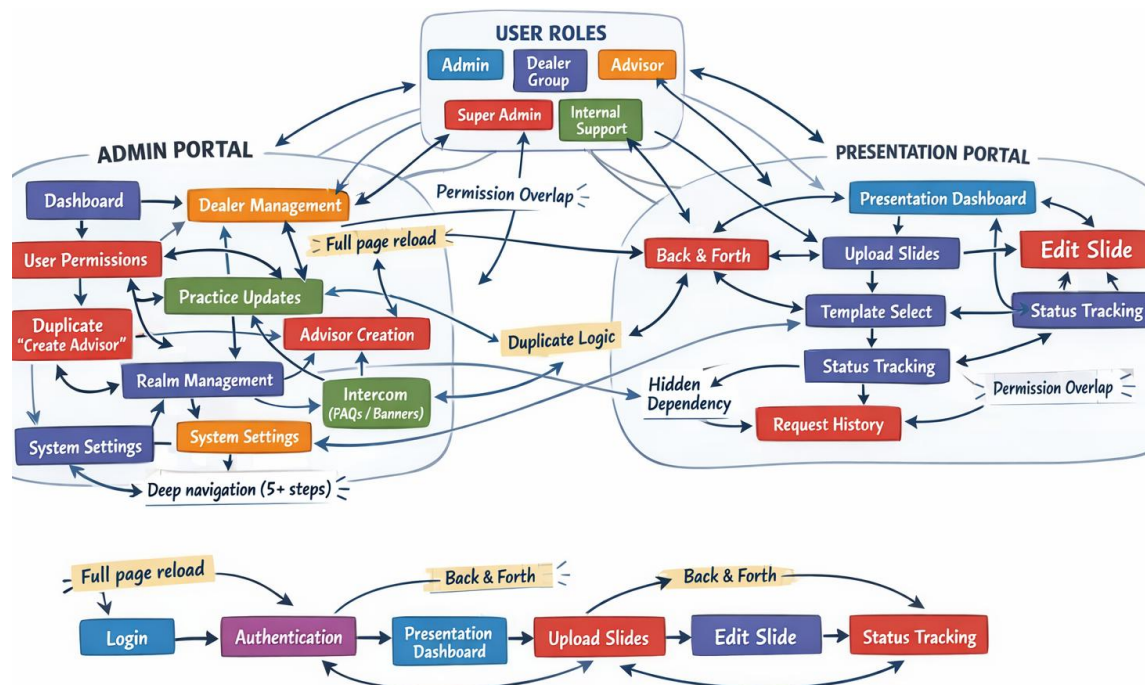
1. Problem

The portal served as a multi-functional administrative and digital presentation system. Over time, incremental feature additions led to structural fragmentation.

Key issues included:

- Inconsistent UI patterns due to lack of unified design system
- Complex admin workflows requiring multi-page navigation
- Poor visibility of role-based permissions and system status
- Fragmented presentation editing experience
- Limited scalability for introducing new features
- Increasing UI debt as new requirements emerged

The system required structural modernization, not just visual improvements.



The core challenge: How might we redesign a complex administrative portal to improve clarity, reduce workflow friction, and create a scalable foundation for future expansion?

2. Constraints

- Live production system (no full rebuild possible)
- Legacy design system built in Adobe XD
- Multiple user roles (Admin, Dealer Group, Advisor, etc.)
- Technical limitations of existing architecture
- Fixed 6-month timeline
- Ongoing feature requests during redesign
- Introduction of a new flowchart feature mid-cycle

The redesign needed to balance modernization with delivery feasibility.

3. Hypothesis

If we:

- Establish a unified design system
- Clarify role-based permissions visually
- Reduce navigation depth using contextual workflows
- Modularize management sections
- Align UX decisions early with engineering constraints

Then we could:

- Reduce cognitive load in admin tasks
- Improve workflow continuity
- Minimize page reload dependency
- Increase scalability for new features
- Reduce long-term design debt

The focus shifted from screen-level improvements to system-level alignment.

4. Design Decisions

A. Design System Migration & Audit

Migration

- Rebuilt legacy screens from Adobe XD into Figma
- Documented layout patterns and interaction behaviors

Audit

- Identified duplicated components
- Highlighted inconsistent spacing and navigation structures

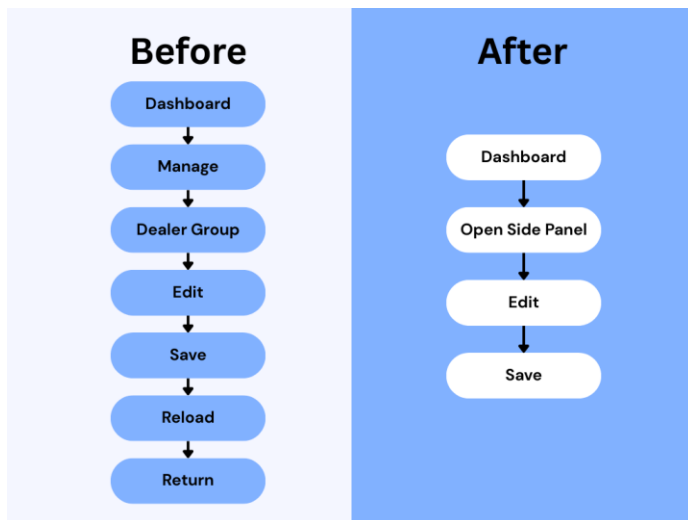
- Mapped workflow friction points

Impact

- Standardized ~80% of recurring UI components into reusable structures
- Created scalable layout grid and component library

B. Admin Portal Enhancements

Side-Panel CRUD Model



Instead of full-page reloads, introduced contextual side-panel Create/Edit/Delete flows to:

- Reduce navigation interruption
- Maintain user context
- Decrease cognitive switching

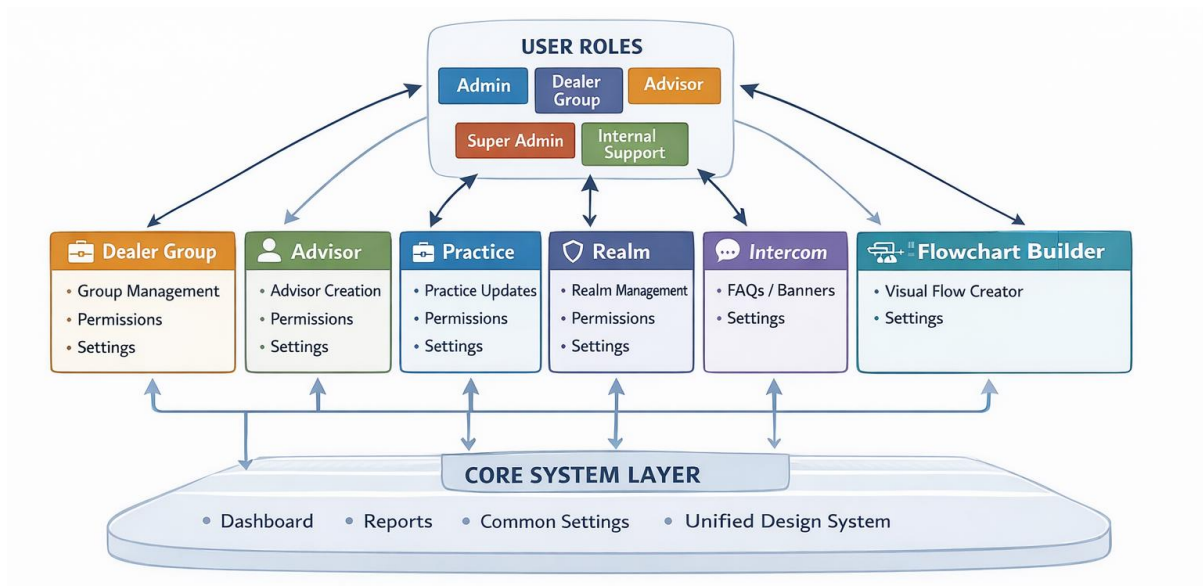
Directional Impact:

Reduced admin task navigation depth (e.g., multi-page flows → contextual 2–3 step flows).

Role-Based Permission Clarity

- Grouped permissions logically
- Improved system status visibility
- Structured admin-type controls

Result: Improved visibility of role hierarchy and reduced permission confusion.



Modular Management Sections

Restructured:

- Dealer Group management
- Advisor creation
- Practice updates
- Realm management
- Intercom management (FAQs, banners)

High-complexity modules were intentionally postponed to maintain delivery realism.

C. Digital Presentation Portal Improvements

Focused on improving presentation creation and tracking.

Enhancements included:

- Dedicated edit mode
- Standardized slide templates (Goal, Thank-you, Calm PV styling)
- Simplified upload flows
- Request history tracking
- Redesigned login & authentication flow

Impact:

- Reduced task confusion
- Improved editing workflow continuity
- Increased visibility of presentation status

D. New Feature: Flowchart Builder

A new requirement introduced a drag-and-connect visual builder.

Process

- Evaluated third-party libraries with developers
- Assessed technical limitations
- Designed interaction patterns within constraints
- Iterated across multiple dev cycles

Trade Alignment

Balanced:

- Library capability limits
- Intuitive UX expectations
- System consistency

5. Tradeoffs

- Prioritized phased rollout over full-system overhaul
- Delayed high-complexity modules to maintain delivery quality
- Adapted ideal UX patterns to fit technical limitations
- Balanced feature expansion with structural consolidation

Rather than designing in isolation, decisions were grounded in engineering feasibility and timeline constraints.

6. Outcome

	Before (Fragmented State)	After (Modular System)
Admin navigation depth	6–8 steps	2–3 contextual steps
Page reload dependency	High (full-page transitions)	Reduced via side-panel flows
Component consistency	Low (duplicate patterns)	~80% standardized system
Workflow clarity	Fragmented, cross-page	Contextual, task-focused
Role visibility	Permission overlap	Structured role hierarchy
Edit experience	Multi-screen switching	Dedicated edit mode
Scalability readiness	Limited, brittle	Modular & extensible
Design debt trajectory	Increasing	Significantly reduced

- The 6-month upgrade delivered measurable structural improvements:
- Reduced admin task navigation depth
- Decreased page reload dependency via side-panel interactions

- Improved visibility of role permissions and system status
- Standardized majority of components into reusable system
- Reduced interface fragmentation across modules
- Improved editing efficiency in presentation workflows
- Established scalable foundation for future feature expansion

Beyond usability, the project significantly reduced future design debt and improved cross-functional alignment.

7. Key Learnings

- Complex systems require structural alignment before visual refinement.
- Contextual side-panel workflows significantly reduce cognitive switching.
- Design system migration is foundational to scalability.
- Early developer collaboration prevents unrealistic UX proposals.
- Phased implementation often produces more sustainable outcomes than full redesigns.
- Feature expansion without structural governance leads to exponential complexity.
- Measurable UX improvements can be achieved even within tight timelines and legacy constraints.